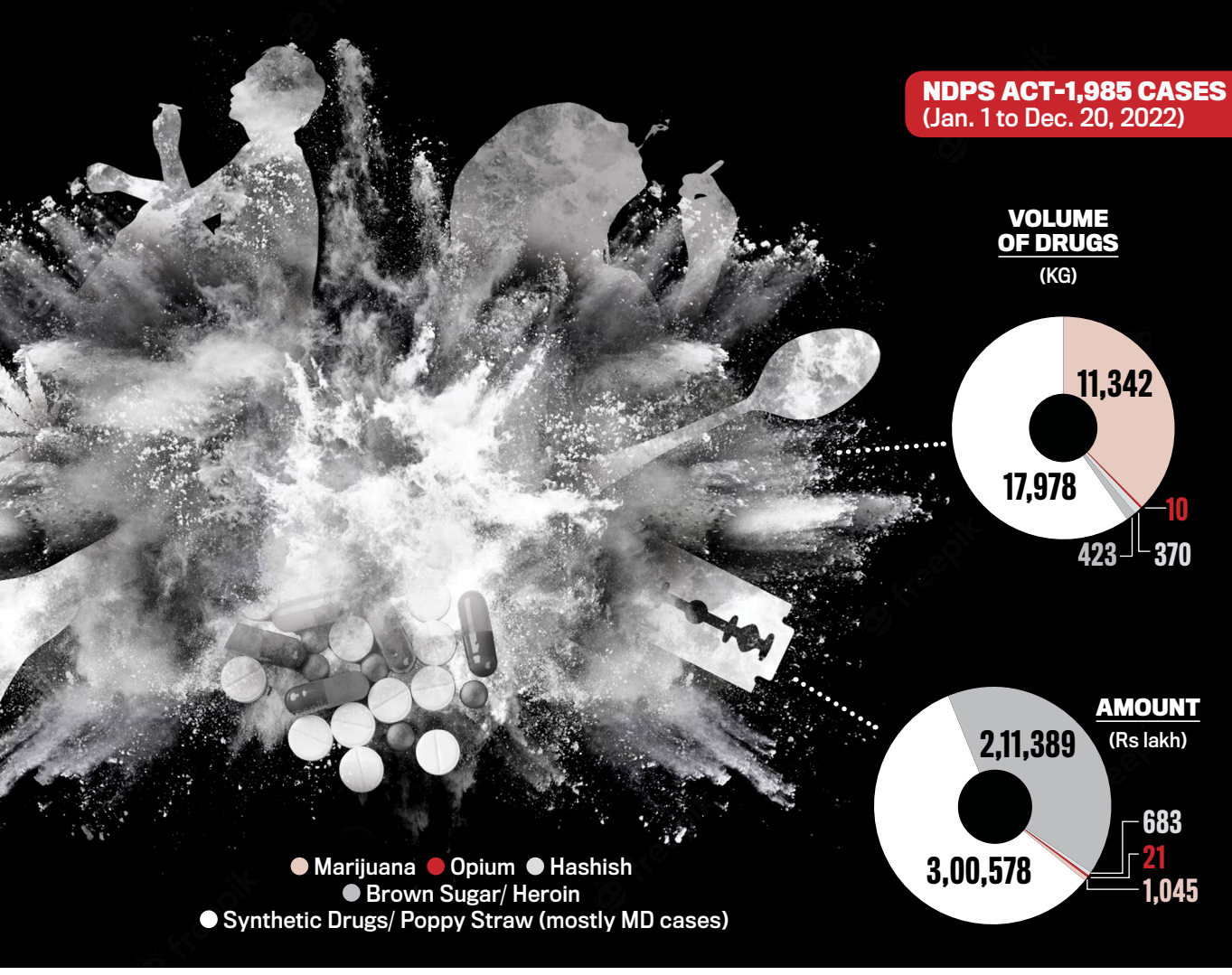


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

who transport the drugs, possibly without knowing the contents of the package. Sometimes, many addicts turn peddlers themselves to sustain their addiction, says Vala.

UDTA GUJARAT?

The reason why MD is becoming a popular drug in India is that the two most commonly consumed drugs in the country, ganja and charas, have become difficult to procure due to strict crackdowns in recent years. Following the abolition of Article 370 in 2019, central agencies have tightened the curbs on movement in Kashmir. Thus, the flow of charas from Kashmir to the rest of the country has also been choked.

Though exact numbers are hard to come by, there is no denying the rise in MD addiction. Addiction therapist Pawar says he has been seeing MD patients for nine years, but the numbers have increased in the past few years.

THE PRE-ARREST PROCEDURES OF THE NDPS ACT ARE QUITE STRINGENT, AND NON-NCB OFFICIALS ARE SCARED OF INVOKING IT

"I am counselling a young CA student who has accumulated lakhs of rupees of debt under MD addiction. He is precariously close to committing a crime every day," he says.

Authorities are also concerned that a growing number of women may be getting addicted to MD. In Ahmedabad city alone, the SOG in the last year arrested nine women peddlers in total, of whom one is absconding. Among them is 52-year-old Ameena Pathan, a hardened criminal who has spent almost a decade in jail for drug-related cases. Another young middle-class Amritsar-based woman working with an event management company was tricked into addiction and became a peddler. She was caught on the streets of Ahmedabad selling 15.5 gm of MD worth Rs 1.55 lakh.

THE WAY OUT

In view of its rising menace, security agencies in Gujarat have stepped up their vigil against MD. State authorities have, in fact, been on high alert since 2018, when intelligence was received from central agencies that Gujarat had emerged as a transit point for drugs. Heroin seizures revealed that the consignments were often headed for the international market. "The drugs are produced in Pakistan-Afghanistan. They then reach Iran, where the consignments are broken